

# Geography and Agriculture in Ancient China

By Katrina Freund, Newsela staff on 06.29.25

Word Count **390**

Level **MAX**



Rice paddies in China's Fujian province. Photo: xu wu, Getty Images Photo: xu wu, Getty Images

China is on the opposite half of the world, but it is still a bit similar to the United States. They are about the same size. They have long coasts, and because of their size, they have many different landscapes. In the past, the landscapes affected how people lived in ancient China. The land and water helped citizens find excellent spots to build homes and plant crops. Farms and towns developed where the land was flat and next to water. This link between water and agriculture, or farming, is important to our understanding of how life was long ago in China.

In ancient China, big rivers like the Yangtze and the Yellow River were significant. Even today, these rivers bring fresh water to the land and make the land excellent for crops. High

mountains and hills made it hard to live in some areas of China. The land was hot and wet in the south and chilly and dry in the north. This mix of rivers, mountains, and climate helped people pick where to live and how to use the land well.

Farming was a big chunk of life in ancient China. In the south, where the land was wet, people planted important crops like rice near the water. Rice farmers have been successful in the area for the last 10,000 years. The rice has helped China feed lots of humans. In the drier north, they planted millet and wheat. The farms were made to fit the land and the weather. Many small huts were built on farms to keep tools and seeds safe. Irrigation of water helped the farmers grow abundant (lots of) food for all the people. Irrigation is a way to send water from the river to dry land.

These excellent agriculture choices were pivotal, or important, to helping towns and cities get big. Places like Nanjing and Shanghai grew as more and more crops were picked. Farming gave food to many and made it possible for people to do more than just work the land. This helped make rich culture, arts, and trade in China.

Geography affected agriculture in ancient China. The land and the rivers helped people know where to start construction on homes and grow food. This abundance, or plenty, of food helped towns expand, shaping a rich culture.

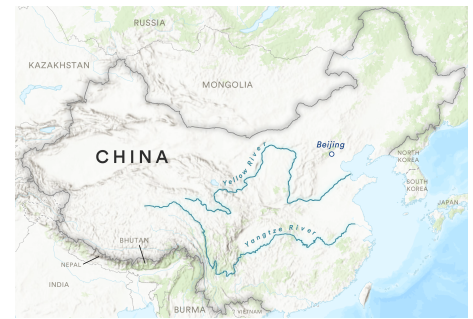


Image 1. Map: Newsela staff